What to charge local businesses in 2026: a price guide by service

Real ranges from surveys, marketplaces and published price lists, checked in November 2026. Use them to build packages you can say with a straight face, not to copy someone else's price. All figures in US dollars.

The quick view

Service	Starting out	Typical	Established / agency	Unit
Website (5–10 pages)	$614–$1,817, avg $1,057 (Thumbtack)	$1,000–$2,500 and $2,500–$5,000 are freelancers' most common bands	most agency projects under $10,000 (Clutch)	one-time
Website care plan (hosting, updates, fixes)	$30–$100	$100–$300	$200–$1,000+	per site, per month
Local SEO retainer	under $500 (30% of agencies)	$501–$1,000 is the most common retainer; local SEO averages $1,557	$2,000–$5,000 (13% of agencies)	per month
Google Business Profile setup	$250	$300–$500	$750	one-time, per location
Google Business Profile management	$125–$400	$300–$600	$800–$1,500	per location, per month
Reviews (getting more, replying)	$95–$135 for software the owner runs	$500–$1,000 managed, small business	$500–$2,500 full reputation management	per month
Social media management	$500–$1,500 basic	$2,107 average for 3 platforms, 3 posts a week each	$5,107 average on Clutch (leans on bigger clients)	per month, ad spend extra
Google Ads management	$250–$1,500 flat	10–20% of ad spend, or $1,000–$3,000 flat	$7,165 average on Clutch (leans on bigger clients)	per month, ad spend extra
Meta (Facebook/Instagram) ads	$500–$1,500 small budgets	10–20% of ad spend	$5,000+ retainers	per month, ad spend extra
AI receptionist / chatbot	the tools alone: $49–$500 a month	what providers quote: $1,500–$5,000 setup +	multi-agent: $5,000–$25,000 setup	setup + monthly

		$300–$1,500 a month		

Sources per row are at the end. GBP, reviews and AI setups have no independent survey yet: those ranges come from companies that sell the service, so treat them as what the market quotes, not an average.

Hourly rates (for scoping, not for quoting)

Who	Rate	Source
SEO freelancer	average $71.59/hr, most common $75–$100	Ahrefs (439 providers)
SEO agency, US/Canada	$100–$149/hr	Clutch 2026
SEO consultant	average $171.18/hr	Ahrefs
Social media manager	average $66.96/hr ($47 at 1–3 years, $92 at 7+ years for freelancers)	HeyOrca 2024 (100+ managers)
Upwork medians (global talent pool)	about $15–$35/hr	Upwork

Owners buy outcomes, not hours. Quote packages; use hours only to check a package is worth your time.

How to set YOUR price in 4 steps

1. **Start from the owner's math.** One job worth $450, half of callers book: a $300/month plan pays for itself with less than 2 extra calls a month. If you can't show that math with their numbers, the price is too high for now.
2. **Pick your three packages** (worksheet section 3): a one-time setup, a recommended monthly plan, a bigger monthly plan. Most owners pick the middle one, so make it the one you want to sell.
3. **Your first 2–3 clients: a founding price.** Lower, time-limited and honest ("I'm taking 3 founding clients in [area] this month"), in exchange for a testimonial, a case study and an introduction.
4. **Raise it after proof.** In a 2026 survey of 622 WordPress agencies, about 1 in 3 was consistently profitable under $5,000 per project and nearly 1 in 2 at $5,000+ (The Admin Bar). Results first, then the price.

Payment terms that protect you

- **Websites:** a deposit before you start. Most web designers ask 25–50% up front; under $5,000, 50% is typical (Contra 2025). The rest at launch, before the site goes live on their domain.
- **Monthly plans:** billed in advance, every month. Reviews and SEO contracts often run 3 to 6 months for small businesses; month-to-month is easier to sell when you're new.
- **Ads:** the client pays the ad platform directly with their own card. You charge only your fee.
- **Notice:** 30 days to cancel, in writing.

Two rules that keep you out of trouble

- **Reviews:** since October 21, 2024, the FTC bans buying or selling fake reviews, paying for positive or negative reviews, and some review-suppression tricks. Google's policy also bans "review gating": asking only happy customers for a review. Any review service you sell must ask every customer.
- **Never promise rankings or a number of calls.** Promise the work and the report; let the numbers speak.

How to read these ranges

The same service can cost 10× more from one provider than another. Three things drive it:

- **Location:** US/Canada agencies charge far more than the global marketplace medians; 22% of US/Canada SEO agencies charge over $2,000 a month vs 9% in Europe (SE Ranking 2024). Big-city agencies quote more than small-town freelancers. Canada-only data is thin: Canadian agencies sit in the same $100–$149/hr band on Clutch.
- **Experience:** SEOs with 2+ years charge about 33% more (Ahrefs); social media freelancers with 7+ years bill about twice the hourly rate of beginners (HeyOrca).
- **Scope:** pages, who writes the copy, platforms, posts per week, ad budget, number of locations.

Surveys are self-reported; Clutch averages lean on big projects; guides from companies that sell the service have a stake in their numbers; some data is older (2021–2024). Your market will vary.

Sources: Website: Thumbtack cost guide (Feb 2025); Paige Brunton web designer survey (771 designers, 2022); Clutch web design pricing (Sep 2026); The Admin Bar, State of the WordPress Agency 2026 (622 agencies). Care plans: Sitewired (2026); FatLab (2026). Local SEO: Ahrefs SEO pricing survey (439 providers); SE Ranking + Duda agency survey (260 agencies, Dec 2024). GBP: Merchynt; Slashpost; CWI (seller guides). Reviews: NiceJob and GatherUp price pages (Nov 2026); WebFX reputation survey (Feb 2025); SurveySparrow (Oct 2026). Social: HeyOrca

pricing report (May 2024); Expertmarket; Clutch. Ads: WebFX; AgencyAnalytics; Stackmatix; Clutch. AI receptionists: Rosie, Goodcall and Smith.ai price pages (Nov 2026); Ciela AI; Taskip (seller guides). Hourly: Ahrefs; Clutch 2026; HeyOrca; Upwork. Payment terms: Contra (Jun 2025). Rules: FTC Trade Regulation Rule on Consumer Reviews and Testimonials (effective Oct 21, 2024); Google review policy. Full links: github.com/WordRocket/local-client-finder/blob/main/playbooks/sources.md. Ranges from published surveys and price guides, not quotes. Results vary.